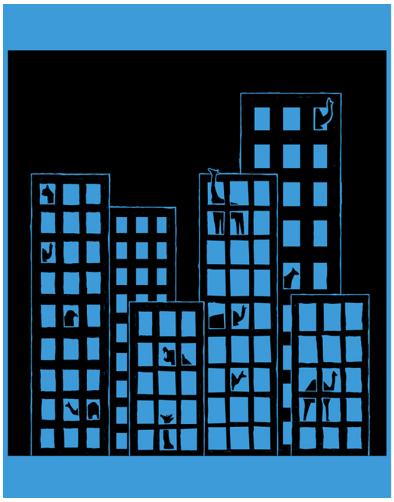


LOCAL COMMUNITIES THAT EXCHANGE COLONISTS

METACOMMUNITIES

IN CONTEXT

KEY FIGURE

Mathew Leibold (1956–)

BEFORE

1917 Arthur Tansley observes that two species of *Galium* plants grow differently in different soil patches.

1934 Georgy Gause develops the competitive exclusion principle stating that two species competing for the same key resource cannot coexist for long.

2001 Stephen Hubbell’s “neutral theory” argues that biodiversity arises at random.

AFTER

2006 Mathew Leibold and fellow American ecologist Marcel Holyoak refine and develop the theory of metacommunities.

One of the limitations of traditional community ecology was that it tended to look at communities purely locally and take little account of what happens at different scales or across different places. Therefore, over the last few decades, ecologists have been developing theories of “meta”